Interestingly, after the East German state archives were opened in 1990, we learned of agreements between the Stasi and PLO, including a pact allowing East Germany to become a base for training PLO operatives planning operations against Israel. To facilitate training, Erich Mielke opened a ‘Department for International Relations’ at a highly guarded compound in the countryside at Kallinchen near Potsdam, on the outskirts of Berlin. Over time, a small but growing flow of PLO militants – including Arafat’s own praetorian guard – took intensive courses in intelligence and counterintelligence operations. ‘These people already know how to fight. They can probably teach us a thing or two about explosives,’ Mielke quipped.5 A former instructor recounted that students were required to undergo single combat training, a course in automatic weapons and learn techniques for interrupting connection systems and radio monitoring. Furthermore, recruits were taught to drive at high speeds, turning manoeuvres, and conditions that would cause hydroplaning.

Punctually at 8 o’clock in the morning, the training started for the Palestinians. The training in the use of weapons and explosives was comprehensive. Soviet products were used including Kalashnikovs and Makarovs. Smaller automatic weapons were also used such as the Scorpion.

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For obvious reasons, the Palestinians did not enter the GDR in the usual way, instead they arrived via neighbouring countries. Border guards waved them through, leaving no traces of their arrival or departure. Throughout the 1970s and 80s, Arafat kept up a healthy flow of correspondence with Honecker, and in return for help received, assisted GDR intelligence officers in Syria and Yemen to discover the extent of undercover CIA and West German activities in the region, although Markus Wolf later admitted that his department had little material to give the Palestinians in exchange.